

Prices

Harmonised index of consumer prices



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Title

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Summary

1 General information on the statistics

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- *Statistical population:* The prices of all goods and services purchased for consumption which are an integral part of household final monetary consumption expenditure in Germany.
- *Statistical unit:* The prices of unvarying products or product offers and also quantities, discounts and other characteristics that are crucial for the quality of the products offered are observed.
- *Reference area:* Harmonised consumer price indices are reported for Germany as a whole.
- *Frequency of data collection:* Prices are collected and results are published every month.
- *Legal acts and other agreements:* European regulations on harmonised indices of consumer prices, Price Statistics Act.

2 Content and user needs

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- *Statistical presentation:* Price index series are provided for household final consumption expenditure in Germany in the form of totals and for individual aggregates.
- *Statistical concepts and definitions:* The prices paid by households are recorded including all excise duties on them.
- *User needs:* The harmonised consumer price index is used especially as inflation measure, as convergence criterion and to the indexation of financial instruments.

3 Methodology

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- *Source data:* While prices are collected to identify price trends, secondary statistics are used to calculate the relevant weighting patterns.
- *Data collection:* Different forms are used for data collection, for example individual survey units, databases, data collection from the internet, online reporting procedures.
- *Data compilation:* An index from type laspeyres is calculated by the collected prices. Enclosed, differences by product type, outlet-type and Land are considered by weighting.

4 Accuracy and reliability

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- *Overall accuracy:* An accuracy of 0.1 percentage points is sought for the overall harmonised index of consumer prices, while inaccuracies are larger at finer levels.
- *Data revision:* The conversions of the weighting and price base takes place every year while a new index base is introduced at ten-year intervals.

5 Timeliness and punctuality

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- *Timeliness*: Generally, provisional results are published shortly before the end of a month. Final results are published around the middle of the month following the reference month.
- *Punctuality*: As a rule, the announced release dates are adhered to.

6 Comparability

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- *Comparability -geographical*: In geographical terms, the indices of the individual EU-Member States are comparable.
- *Comparability over time*: Comparability over time at European level has been ensured.

7 Coherence

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- *Coherence – cross domain*: The harmonised index of consumer prices, the consumer price index and the retail price index are derived from the same database by different methods.

8 Dissemination and communication

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- *Dissemination format*: The results of the HICP are available to all users at the same time on the website of the Federal Statistical Office.

9 Comment

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- None.

1 General information on the statistics

1.1 Statistical population

The statistical population of the harmonised index of consumer prices (HICP) comprises the prices of all goods and services purchased in the domestic territory, which are an integral part of household final monetary consumption expenditure in Germany. However, the statistical population of both the HICP and the national consumer price index (CPI) does not include, for instance, social contributions (like statutory health insurance premiums), transfers (such as donations or fines) and purchases from other households (for instance second-hand goods).

The statistical population of the HICP differs from that of the CPI only in some respects. Owner-occupied housing has so far not been included in the HICP while, in the national consumer price index (CPI), the owner-occupied housing is estimated, taking the development of the price index for net rents exclusive of heating expenses as a basis (rental equivalence approach). Similarly, unlike the CPI, the HICP does not include the radio licence fee since 2020. With the implementation of the new classification of the ECOICOP Version 2, some additional items are added to the HICP. In the CPI, these will only become effective retroactively with the CPI revision, as the CPI revision will only include the transition to the new classification structures in 2028. With the reporting month of January 2026, the HVPI will first record the household consumption expenditure for games of chance.

1.2 Statistical unit

Survey unit: Prices are collected from representatively selected retail stores and service units (for example companies, stores, outlets), including public and state providers. Private households, which let one (or more) flat(s) to other private households are considered service providers (companies) and thus equal to survey units.

Observation unit: The prices of unvarying products or product offers and also quantities, discounts and other characteristics that are crucial for the quality of the products offered are observed. A product selected for price observation is replaced by other offers if it is sold either seldom or no longer. Prices paid by households are recorded, including all excise duties on them. These are usually sales prices (offer prices and actual prices), but partly also rents, fees or surcharges.

Presentation unit: The results of the HICP are calculated as totals and in a technical (subject-related) breakdown, as a rule down to the five-digit level of the European Classification of Individual Consumption by Purpose (ECOICOP Version 2). All results are shown in the form of price indices (index numbers). In addition, rates of change compared to the same month of the previous year or the previous month are shown.

1.3 Reference area

The HICP is reported for Germany as a whole, but not for the individual Länder. In accordance with the requirements of the [Statistical Office of the European Union \(Eurostat\)](#), the index is also constructed in a similar manner for the other Member States of the European Union, as well as for some non-EU countries. In addition to the HICP for the individual countries, Eurostat publishes HICPs for the European Union and for the euro area.

1.4 Reference period

The reference period is the relevant calendar month. Around the middle of the month, prices are collected over a period of at least one week. However, the price collection period is longer for products whose prices fluctuate considerably during the month. This applies, for instance, to mineral oil products, fresh fruit and vegetables, and clothing. In addition, results are calculated and published for the calendar year.

1.5 Frequency of data collection

Prices are collected and results are published every month.

1.6 Legal acts and other agreements

At European level, Regulation (EU) 2016/792 and the Delegated Regulation (EU) 2024/3159 are applicable. In addition, the HICP takes into account Implementing Regulation (EU) 2020/1148, 2024/1720 and (EU) 2025/1182.

The EU legal acts in their up-to-date version and in the German language are available on the website of the Publications Office of the European Union at <http://eur-lex.europa.eu/>

As the harmonised index of consumer prices calculated for European purposes and the national consumer price index are derived from the same data basis, German legislation is of relevance to the HICP for Germany, too. All national legal bases valid for the national CPI should be mentioned in this context:

- Act on Statistics for Federal Purposes (Federal Statistics Act - BStatG)
- Price Statistics Act (PreisStatG)

The up-to-date wording of the relevant national legislation can be found at <https://www.gesetze-im-internet.de/>.

1.7 Confidentiality

1.7.1 Confidentiality - policy

The individual data collected are always kept confidential in accordance with Section 16 of the Federal Statistics Act (BStatG). Only in exceptional cases explicitly regulated by law may individual data be passed on. Pursuant to Section 16 (6) of the Federal Statistics Act, institutions of higher education or other institutions tasked with independent scientific research may, for the purpose of carrying out scientific projects, be provided

- with individual data if attributing the anonymised individual data to the relevant respondents or persons concerned requires unreasonable effort in terms of time, cost and manpower (de facto anonymised individual data),
- with access to individual data not including name and address (formally anonymised individual data) within specially protected areas of the Federal Statistical Office and the statistical offices of the Länder, if effective measures are in place to safeguard confidentiality.

The obligation of confidentiality also applies to those persons who are recipients of individual data.

1.7.2 Confidentiality - data treatment

At the finest level of detail, too, only highly aggregated results are published. The sampling technique ensures that the results published are based on a sufficient number of price observations.

Information that could be attributed to individual companies are also kept confidential (primary confidentiality). If results are mathematically related, so-called secondary locks must be applied in addition to the primary locks.

1.8 Quality management

1.8.1 Quality assurance

The HICP is compiled in accordance with both comprehensive provisions in the relevant legal bases and the European methodological guidelines and requirements. Differences to the national consumer price index are documented and explained to users. The delivery and publication dates for the German HICP are agreed before the start of each year. Generally, the results of the German HICP and the national CPI are published at the same time.

A processing program is used for computation purposes for both the German HICP and the national CPI. It controls the individual process steps from price collection through to the calculation of results and carries out, and documents comprehensibly, (nearly) all calculations. Plausibility checks are built each stage of processing to prevent data entry errors by issuing warnings if implausible data are entered. Critical data that have been entered by price collectors must be confirmed and/or be specified by specially trained staff of the statistical offices. Additionally, the processing program computes indicators as a basis for further quality checks. Among other things, the most peculiar results must be listed for each product type and be checked by appropriately trained staff of the statistical offices after the computation of the Länder results. Furthermore, specially trained staff of the Federal Statistical Office again compares the results of the various Länder. Data that differ considerably will be checked once more.

The "Verbraucherpreise" working group, which comprises representatives of the Federal Statistical Office and the statistical offices of the Länder, regularly analyses weaknesses in the process of statistical production and develops quality improvement methods.

Eurostat, the Statistical Office of the European Union, additionally carries out its own data checks for HICP. It regularly requests reports on national computation practices and monitors compliance with European requirements during so-called [Compliance Monitoring](#). The results are published on the internet. Due to the common data basis, they are relevant to quality assurance activities in relation to the national CPI, too. In addition to an assessment of compliance with the requirements of EU regulations, the results comprise recommendations for improvement whose implementation is monitored by Eurostat. The overarching goal is to ensure that all national HICPs meet the high standards of the European Statistics Code of Practice regarding relevance, accuracy and reliability, timeliness and punctuality, coherence and comparability, and accessibility and clarity in view of their importance for the European economic policy.

1.8.2 Quality assessment

The German HICP distinguishes itself especially by its high relevance for inflation measurement, comparability within the European Union, accuracy and very good timeliness. Special importance is attached to the transparency of data collection and computation methods. Fulfilling the relevant requirements, the HICP serves as a central indicator of inflation trends in Europe and a standard for comparing the national consumer price developments. The concepts and methods of the HICP, which are based on the experiences of all EU Member States in the area of consumer price statistics, were developed in accordance with international standards. Continuous efforts are being made to improve the quality and comparability of the HICP.

2 Content and user needs

2.1 Statistical presentation

2.1.1 Data description

As regards the harmonised index of consumer prices (HICP), price index series are provided for household final consumption expenditure in Germany in the form of totals and for individual aggregates (compare with presentation units under 1.2). Year-on-year and month-on-month inflation rates are also available. Furthermore, the Statistical Office of the European Union (Eurostat) also publishes the weights of the individual sub-indices in the overall index.

2.1.2 Classification system

The technical (subject-related) breakdown of the units of presentation is based on the structure of the [European Classification of Individual Consumption according to Purpose \(ECOICOP Version 2\)](#).

2.1.3 Statistical concepts and definitions

Central concepts and definitions of the HICP:

- The statistical population of the HICP comprises the prices of all goods and services purchased in the domestic territory which are an integral part of household final monetary consumption expenditure in Germany.
- The underlying approach is the domestic concept, that is, all expenditure in Germany - including, for instance, that of foreign tourists - is taken into account.
- The prices paid by households are recorded, including all excise duties on them. General price reductions and reductions that can be assigned to the products concerned are taken into account. In order to allow price trends at European level that are not attributable to state interference (e.g. tax policy or fees regulations) at the national level, the HICP at constant tax rates (HICP-CT) and the HICP at administered prices (HICP-AP) are also calculated. The effects of observed state measures on the HICP can be determined by comparing the HICP-CT and the HICP.
- Intra-sectoral flows (for instance a household's second-hand purchases from another household without involving resellers) are not covered. An exception is the letting of dwellings by households to other households (a private household as a landlord belongs to the enterprise sector).

- As, in addition to inflation measurement, the comparability of inflation rates is an important objective, a special focus is on the HICP methodological harmonisation in the European countries. For this reason, methodological adjustments may take place every year, which makes the comparison of pure price changes more difficult. This effect is countered by a new EU regulation (EU) 2024/1720, which mandates the use of level shift factors. Annual changes in the structures of product offers or in the consumption patterns are also reflected in the HICP. However, data of preceding periods (also the previous year) are usually not recalculated; instead the indices are chain-linked every year through the relevant December value (Laspeyres chain index concept).

When applying the relevant approaches, some special aspects have to be borne in mind. For instance, quantity and quality changes to the products covered are excluded from measurements of price development. This is done using internationally recognised methods and, in most cases, the results obtained are satisfactory (see also 3.3). In some cases, however, statisticians face challenging problems in assessing quality or quality differences, for instance, if the quality of a book or concert performance is to be evaluated. An objective "quality measurement" is not feasible in those cases. The official statistics have agreed on the application of the so-called "best-seller approach". Here the prices for the currently best-selling books or concerts are directly compared monthly without quality adjustment. However, extreme price fluctuations can occur in this type of price measurement, which can be explained by the method itself and background knowledge. Moreover, this best-seller approach only applies to goods with a very low overall weighting.

Currently, generally recognised, recommended or agreed methods are not in place for price measurements in a number of consumption expenditure segments. For instance, practical data collection problems prevent the inclusion of illegal and grey area transactions. For example, prices for the illegal arms trade or the black market for domestic services, which are theoretically part of the survey population, cannot be considered. Also, prices for drugs and prostitution services are not included either at the moment.

2.2 User needs

The HICP is used by various users especially for the following three purposes:

- Inflation measure: The HICP is a central indicator of inflation trends in Europe. Therefore, it is especially important that the indices are calculated on an internationally comparable basis and can be aggregated to obtain European price indices, for instance, for the European Union (EU) or the euro area. In addition to the European Central Bank (ECB), users of the HICP are the central national banks, the European Commission and analysts.
- Convergence criterion: The convergence criterion on price stability is a central criterion to decide whether an EU Member State is admitted to the euro area.
- Indexation of financial instruments: The HICP is used as a compensation benchmark for some bonds like, for instance, inflation-indexed federal bonds. Here the interest rate to be paid annually is based on the HICP development in the relevant period. Generally, the HICP's primary purpose as an inflation measure that is comparable between all EU Member States and the entailed continuous

methodological development make it more difficult to use the HICP as a compensation benchmark. Methodological changes have a direct effect on the rates of price increase shown by the HICP. This limits comparability over time. The use of the HICP as a compensation benchmark is therefore not recommended.

2.3 User satisfaction

Methodological changes are discussed and coordinated at the EU level and are laid down in regulations or guidelines. The ECB, central national banks and the European Commission as users take part in the consultations. Other users are involved through various bodies at the EU level.

3 Statistical processing

3.1 Source data

For the index calculation of the HICP and the CPI, a common data collection is carried out, as the data basis for both indices is largely identical (see 1.1). So, the concept of gathering data for purposes of the harmonised index of consumer prices (HICP) for Germany corresponds to the concept of data gathering for the national consumer price index (CPI). However, various forms of gathering data are used to construct both the HICP for Germany and the CPI. While prices are collected to identify price trends, secondary statistics are used to calculate the relevant weighting patterns.

Price collection:

HICP calculations are based on a basket which is representative of all goods and services purchased by households in Germany. The basket could be said to have two levels of content.

At the upper level the basket contains different types of products to which weighting factors (weights) are assigned in order to reflect the various price trends in computing the overall HICP. At this level the basket remains unchanged over a period of at least one year (see also 4.4.1).

From the different types of goods of the basket's upper level, individual products are then selected for price collection purposes in each of the selected shops. These individual products represent the lower level of the basket. At this level of individual price representatives, the basket is continuously updated as products which are no longer offered or become less important in the market need to be replaced, or completely new product variants need to be added.

At the lower level of the basket, several hundred thousand individual prices are recorded manually at retail stores and service units every month. This until now usual price collection includes on the one hand the decentralised price collection by price collectors in shops all over Germany and on the other hand the central price collection, which takes place mainly as a survey on the internet.

The additional use of digital data sources allows the statistical offices to increase the number of monthly price observations significantly. For example, for sectors with particularly complex pricing, such as flights, additional data sources with a high number of observations are used. In addition, modern survey methods such as Web Scraping are used, to supplement and replace manual surveys. Web Scraping is an automated extraction of internet data. Using such procedures, the number of monthly

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price observations for online trade and for selected services - such as rental cars - has been extended considerably in the light of dynamic price changes.

Since the beginning of 2023, additional transaction data has been used for price collection. This leads to a qualitative improvement in the collection of package holidays, since only the actual trips are taken into account in the index calculation. At the same time, the publication could be extended to different destinations.

All recorded data are aggregated for the types of goods (upper level) which are included in the weighting pattern for goods and services with their relevant shares within household final consumption expenditure (see also Data sources for weighting). The weighting pattern at least considers all types of products whose shares within the total consumption expenditure of households in Germany are above 1 per mill. A stricter rule applies to seasonal goods. These are already included if their share of expenditure during the offer period - which in extreme cases can be as little as one month - is 1 per mill. A stricter rule applies to seasonal goods. These are already included if their share of expenditure during the offer period - which in extreme cases can be as little as one month - is 2 per mill. The requirements for the limit values result from the European regulations for the HICP.

For the purpose of price collection, the territory of the Federal Republic of Germany in a first step is subdivided into 16 Länder with just under 100 regions. In each of those regions, generally representative cities, towns and municipalities and afterwards representative outlets are selected, using a purposive sampling procedure. The different market shares of the outlet types (for example department stores, supermarkets, specialised outlets, online shops) are taken into account by explicit weighting. All outlet types whose market shares amount to at least 5% for a certain type of good are covered. The Federal Statistical Office has very detailed specifications for selecting individual products, which are supplemented with information about specific regional characteristics that is available at the statistical offices of the Länder and from price collectors. On that basis, price collectors collect the prices of the most frequently sold products from the relevant reporting units. The number of products selected is especially based on the share of a given type of items within the total household consumption expenditure.

Data sources for weighting:

In addition to the weighting pattern for goods and services, weighting patterns for outlet types and for the Länder are used in constructing both the HICP and the national CPI. Actually, various secondary data sources are used to calculate the individual weighting patterns:

- Outlet-type weighting: The calculation of the outlet-type weights is based on market research data on household expenditure or distributions of turnover in retail trade and on official trade statistics. As regards the regionalisation of outlet-type weights at the Länder level, the relevant information available at the statistical offices of the Länder is additionally used.
- Länder weighting: Länder weights are derived from the information on household final consumption expenditure in the domestic territory that is provided in the national accounts of the Länder. As these are not broken down to the level of

product types (Classification of Income and Expenditure of Households - SEA-CPI - 10-digit level), the Land weights are the same for all types of products.

- **Weighting of goods and services:** The weighting pattern for the HICP is derived from the weighting pattern for the national CPI. Every five years, the latter is redetermined based on a very comprehensive and detailed evaluation of a large number of different data sources and it is specified in a very detailed manner. The results of the National Accounts, the sample survey of income and expenditure and the continuous household budget surveys provide the basis for calculating the weighting pattern. For reconciliation purposes and the further breakdown of the weighting pattern, results from other statistics are used, for example statistics of other authorities as the registration of new vehicles of the Federal Motor Transport Authority and results from market research institutes. Overcoverage or undercoverage known in several statistics must be rectified in order to calculate the weighting pattern. For instance, the consumption of alcohol and tobacco indicated in the sample survey of household income and expenditure and in the continuous household budget surveys is too low. Therefore, the data are adjusted using the results of excise duty statistics. Furthermore, the household budget surveys include sales within the private sector (for example of used cars). As the respective data are not to be included in the HICP, they have to be adjusted using other data, for instance, of the Federal Motor Transport Authority. Compared with the CPI weighting pattern, the coverage of the HICP weighting pattern is somewhat smaller as the latter has so far included neither owner-occupied housing nor the radio licence fee.

At the level of rough weights (ECOICOP two to five-digit), the HICP weighting pattern differs in an additional point from that of the CPI. The HICP focuses on the timeliness of the weights. In accordance with the EU Regulation, the rough weights have been updated annually since January 2012 using provisional results of the national accounts from the previous year (t-2) and subsequently adjusted to reflect price developments up to December of the previous year (t-1).

The Corona pandemic, which continued until 2022, with its restrictions on public life and the resulting consequences, necessitates an adjustment of the usual approach to updating the HICP goods weights. In line with the Eurostat's recommendations, the HICP weights for the years 2021 to 2023 were derived on the basis of provisional annual results of National Accounts (NA) in the previous year (t-1). These were subject to greater uncertainties than the more recent national accounts data (t-2), usually used in previous years, but reflect the significantly shifted expenditure structure due to the pandemic. After thorough review of the improved quality of the preliminary annual results of the previous year's national accounts (t-1), these have been used as standard since 2024 to maintain the advantage of timeliness.

Further information is provided in the article "[Compilation of the HICP weighting pattern for the year 2026 \(price base December 2025\)](#)".

3.2 Data collection

Price collection:

The most efficient of the following forms of data collection is used for each of the given product types:

- In the individual survey units, the prices are collected by price collectors from the statistical offices of the Länder.
- As regards retail chains with a uniform pricing structure, a central survey is conducted by specially trained price collectors in one branch of the retail chain concerned.
- Catalogues, price systems, fee scales, laws and administrative regulations are analysed and evaluated.
- Manual and automated survey on the internet.
- Special databases are searched or data are purchased from private providers.
- Data are transmitted by respondents using the IDEV online reporting procedure or survey units are called on the telephone regarding selected products.

Price collectors from the statistical offices collect the prices of a large part of goods and services directly in the survey units. To measure the price movement, they every month collect the prices of the same products in the same outlets across the whole country, mostly using mobile data capture devices with integrated plausibility checks. The principle of always observing the prices of the same products applies to the other forms of data collection, too. An item once selected for price observation is however replaced by another item if it is sold either seldom or no longer. As a rule, the survey programme is basically reviewed before changing over to a new base year. This refers both to selecting the observation units and determining the variables to be collected and to adjusting the standards for the distribution of survey units across regions and outlet types.

Data sources for weighting:

Please note the quality reports on the official statistics indicated under 3.1 for information on preparing data collection and collecting data from the basic sources used to compile the HICP weighting pattern. The quality reports are available at www.destatis.de > Methods > Quality.

3.3 Data compilation

Price index calculation:

The price index calculations are largely carried out by a processing program. As a first step, data that are temporarily missing (for instance due to seasonal effects) are estimated using appropriate methods, that is, generally on the basis of the price development of comparable products. In addition, quantity and quality adjustment procedures ensure that 'like is compared with like' when measuring prices, despite changes in the products offered. As a result, price changes can be interpreted as pure price movements. Different methods are used for quality adjustment. In many cases, an old product offered can be replaced by a new one with at least roughly comparable quality. Here a direct comparison of prices will be feasible. Sometimes,

however, it is not possible to find products in the market that are comparable in terms of quality and are representative at the same time. In those cases, the quality difference between the products replaced and the relevant replacement products is determined using appropriate methods of calculation. That difference is then deducted from the total price change. Hedonic quality adjustment is for instance used for desktop PCs, notebooks and used cars, while option pricing (feature adjustment), as it is known, is one of the techniques applied to new cars.

As a next step, the processing program computes an elementary index typically based on the Dutot formula for each product type in an outlet type in a Land. To this end, the ratio is calculated of the average prices between the reference and the base period. The price base of the HICP is always the month of December of the year before the reference year (t-1).

The elementary indices determined in this way are aggregated using the Laspeyres formula. This type of index measures price trends over time while taking into account neither quantity nor quality changes. As regards the product types for which outlet-type weights are available, the processing program calculates from the elementary indices a sub-index for a given product type in a Land, using the product-specific outlet-type weights. As a next step, the Länder results for the respective product types are added up using the Länder weights to obtain federal results. To construct the overall HICP, the sub-indices for the product types weighted by outlet types and Länder are weighted with the relevant expenditure proportions of the annually updated HICP weighting pattern. The HICP is a chain index and the weights are updated annually. Its individual elements are chained to form a price index series for a longer period. Rates of price change, such as the inflation rate measured by the HICP, are derived from the price index series at the end of processing.

3.4 Adjustment

Methods of calendar or seasonal adjustment are not published by the Federal Statistical Office. However, in addition to the HICP, a harmonised index of consumer prices at administered prices (HICP-AP) and a harmonised index of consumer prices at constant tax rates (HICP-CT) are calculated in order to determine price trends that are not affected by state interference.

3.5 Cost and burden

The response burden on survey units can be regarded as low as the survey is mainly carried out by qualified price collectors. Survey (reporting) units are only affected in cases of written or telephone interviews or when questions come up during data collection (for example because of insufficient price labelling). In most cases, the survey units only have to allow data collection on their enterprises, establishments or branches. There is no burden on the survey unit in case of internet survey or the use of digital data sources.

4 Accuracy and reliability

4.1 Overall accuracy

The prices of a sample of individual products are collected and taken as a data basis for calculating the harmonised index of consumer prices (HICP) and also for HICP analyses. As sampling is based on mainly purposive selection, the sampling error

cannot be formally calculated or estimated. To keep the unknown sampling error as low as possible, however, the very high number of prices are collected every month and a highly sophisticated stratification model is applied (see 3.1). Non-sampling errors are not quantified in HICP construction. Activities such as continuously improving the methodology and taking a wide range of quality assurance measures at different levels (see 1.8.1 and 4.3) are however intended to reduce non-sampling errors to a minimum. An accuracy of 0.1 percentage points is sought for the overall HICP, while inaccuracies are larger at finer levels of detail regarding, in particular, the expenditure on products with a small importance for consumption.

The generally high accuracy of the harmonised index of consumer prices has also been confirmed by the relevant CPI analyses made during method change-induced revisions (see 4.4.3) where, in most cases, noteworthy revision differences have only been the result of methodological improvements. Method changes in the HICP are mostly implemented in a similar manner, although not at the same time as the CPI.

Discrepancies between provisional and final results have been small (a maximum of +/-0.2 percentage points to date).

4.2 Sampling error

Constructing the HICP, the rent survey uses random sampling. A sampling frame is not available from which a random sample could be drawn either directly or with reasonable effort. Purposive selection, mostly in combination with the cut-off principle, is instead used in drawing the sample. For this reason, a sampling error cannot be formally calculated or estimated although there are sampling-related errors. The better the survey population is reflected in the sample, the better the quality of purposive sampling combined with the cut-off principle. Therefore, special importance is attached to the quality of the computation basis for sample stratification. To keep the unknown sampling error as low as possible, the very high number of prices are collected every month and a highly sophisticated stratification model is applied. It can be assumed that the monthly development of prices is reflected very accurately in both the overall index and aggregated sub-indices using this non-random procedure.

4.3 Non-sampling error

Non-sampling errors are not quantified in HICP construction. Continuously improving the methodology is however intended to reduce non-sampling errors to a minimum. This refers to the following types of errors, in particular:

- Systematic errors due to deficiencies in the sampling frame: An individual sampling frame is not available. For the HICP this is compiled from different sources. Gaps are closed by estimates.
- Errors because of non-response (units and variables/items): Compared to other surveys, non-response is very low because, typically, individuals or enterprises are not questioned or interviewed. Instead, prices are collected by specially trained price collectors. It may nonetheless happen that information is justifiably missing, for instance, because a survey unit is closed for holidays or an observation unit cannot be visited as it only operates on a seasonal basis. Regarding such temporary phenomena, updating procedures are integrated in the processing program to prevent biases. The relevant automated calculations are initiated by

specific code-based routines. In cases of permanent non-response (if, for instance, a unit ceases to operate or a product is no longer offered), the price collectors have to look for substitutes without delay. They are appropriately trained to comply with the general rules for replacing observation and survey units. Each case will finally be transmitted to a specially qualified staff member of the competent statistical office to take a final decision or determine the further procedure.

Special situations such as floods or pandemics can also lead to price falls - even on a larger scale. In addition to the usual update methods, imputation procedures were also used, during the 2020 to 2023 coronavirus pandemic, and their qualitative limitations are indicated/marked.

- **Compilation and processing errors:** As the processing program incorporates consistency and plausibility checks, measurement or data entry errors are largely prevented in the process of data compilation. Inconsistent entries are rejected by the processing program. Owing to the incorporated plausibility checks, warning messages are displayed if, for instance, atypical price or quantity changes occur. If a warning message is ignored, the relevant case will be automatically shown to a specially qualified staff member of the competent statistical office for final assessment or clarification. Processing errors are prevented by automated routines or calculations of the processing program.
- **Effects depending on the model used:** The informative value of price trend measurements using Laspeyres indices is limited. Typically, the weights are kept constant over a relatively long period of time when applying the Laspeyres formula (fixed-base index). Although the structure of household expenditure changes slowly, however, it does so from year to year. To account for changes in the structure of household expenditure, the HICP weighting pattern is updated every year. In addition, methodological adjustments are implemented shortly after they have been decided. Unlike the CPI, the HICP is a Laspeyres chain index, which generally does not need to recalculate data of preceding periods. In contrast to the national CPI, the HICP is therefore affected by changing consumption patterns and methodological changes.

The calculation models used correspond to the relevant international standards regarding inflation measurement and the comparison of inflation rates in Europe. For alternative purposes such as using the index as a compensation benchmark, another approach like, for instance, another revision practice may be more appropriate.

4.4 Data revision

4.4.1 Data revision - policy

Routine revisions: In addition to final results, provisional HICP results are published. At the end of a reference month, the provisional results are estimated on the basis of provisional Länder results available by that time. In the middle of the following month, the final results will be published based on the complete range of final data in place.

Methodological revisions: In the national consumer price index (CPI) these usually take place every five years. A new base year will be introduced and a revised survey catalogue will be used as a basis. In addition, weighting pattern will also be updated, new methods are introduced and existing ones updated. Unlike the national CPI, the Statistisches Bundesamt, Quality Report, Prices

HICP differentiates between the weighting, price and index bases. The changeover to a new weighting base (see 3.1) takes place annually in the 13th months following the end of the reference year. So, for instance, the weighting base was changed to 2025 in January 2026. In this context, methodological changes are also introduced, where appropriate. The price base for the current reference year is December of the previous year (for instance December 2025 for the year 2026). Together with the weighting base, the price base is adjusted every year. A new index base is introduced at ten-year intervals, and more precisely one month after the end of the reference years ending in 5 (for instance, the index base was the year 2015 from January 2016, and since January 2026 it has been the year 2025). As a general rule, the HICP results are usually not recalculated retrospectively (revised); instead they are chain-linked to the data published previously. This also applies if more up-to-date weighting information is available. Methodological changes in the HICP are documented, and a level shift factor is applied as needed and made available to users upon request.

4.4.2 Data revision - practice

Routine revisions: see 4.4.1

Methodological revisions: The adjustment by changing the weighting base and the price base shall be systematically prepared. To update the weighting pattern for goods and services as of January of a year, the rough weights of the previous year are updated using both consumption expenditure results of national accounts and information on price development (see 3.1). In addition, the price base is changed annually to December of the previous year. Unless otherwise required by law, methodological changes implemented in the CPI are incorporated in the HICP at about the same time, too. An HICP Regulation stipulates the introduction of a new index base at ten-year intervals. In general, this is achieved by just rebasing the price series in place. Normally, methodological changes in the HICP do not entail a recalculation (that is revision) of the data of previous periods. Effects on the current results are estimated by means of special calculations (supported either by an unofficial recalculation of previous year's results in accordance with the new methods or an additional calculation of the current results using the old methods). The results are made available to the users as required. However, the adjustment of the weighting pattern for goods and services in CPI revisions has an impact on the lowest level of the HICP weighting derivation. The updating of the CPI weights for business types and Länder also has an index effect in the HICP.

4.4.3 Data revision - analysis

In Germany, the impact of individual methodological changes is usually determined on the basis of the national CPI and published in articles on the occasion of the introduction of a new base year (in the CPI: index base = weighting base = price base). The results obtained for the CPI can in principle be transferred to the HICP, but not in detail due to the different coverage of the CPI and the HICP.

For major methodological changes, pre-implementation analyses are also carried out for the HICP in order to assess their impact (see Elbel, G.: "[Harmonisierter Verbraucherpreisindex: Jährliche Aktualisierung der Gewichtung](#)", WiSta 03/2015). This makes it possible to revise the HICP for Germany in the event of major impacts (see Egner, U.: "[Verbraucherpreisstatistik auf neuer Basis 2015](#)", WiSta 05/2019).

The impact of implementing ECOICOP Version 2 was also analysed in advance, and as a result of the significant structural changes, the past was adjusted or recalculated (back date).

5 Timeliness and punctuality

5.1 Timeliness

Provisional results: Generally, provisional results are published shortly before the end of a month. Exceptions are the reference months of December (public holidays) and February (short month). More exceptions due to calendar irregularities can be specified. Those exceptions are included in the release calendars and announced on the internet before the start of a new calendar year.

Final results: Final results of the monthly harmonised index of consumer prices (HICP) are published around the middle of the month following the reference month.

5.2 Punctuality

As a rule, the announced release dates are adhered to.

6 Comparability

6.1 Comparability - geographical

In geographical terms, the harmonised indices of consumer prices of the individual EU Member States are comparable as the same system is applied in all countries. Definitions and classifications are harmonised legal standards, which ensures that the statistical population is defined equally in all European countries. The national weighting patterns differ in order to take account of the specific consumption habits in the individual countries. Since January 2012, however, all Member States have been obliged once a year to review their weighting pattern and to adjust it, using provisional results, for instance, of national accounts for the year $t-2$ or $t-1$. In addition, efforts are continuously being made to increase the level of harmonisation between the countries in the areas of quality adjustment procedures and sampling in order to further strengthen HICP comparability between the EU Member States.

6.2 Comparability over time

HICP comparability over time at European level has been ensured since the calculation was introduced in 1996. Methodological changes or changes in the consumption and shopping habits are made annually to ensure that the HICP is up-to-date as a basis for policy decisions. Annual weighting adjustments may lead to breaks and distortions, but do not constitute methodological changes in the strict sense. For larger breaks and distortions, revisions are also possible for the HICP to ensure comparability over time (see 4.4.3).

7 Coherence

7.1 Coherence - cross domain

To some extent, the results of other statistics concerning similar aspects differ from the results of the harmonised index of consumer prices (HICP). The differences arise on the one hand from the objective of the price statistics, which is to measure price development in the different economic sectors and at the different economic levels.

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On the other hand, since 2025, there have been significant structural changes due to the implementation of ECOICOP Version 2 in the HICP, which affect comparability with results based on ECOICOP version 1. To ensure comparability, the previous results were retroactively transferred to the new classification structures from 1996 (back data).

- Consumer price index for Germany (CPI): Basically the CPI, like the HICP, is intended to measure the development of prices in relation to household final consumption expenditure in the domestic territory. Both indices are derived from a common database. As a rule, this refers to both calculating weighting patterns and collecting prices at monthly intervals. Hence the results of the German HICP and the German national CPI are identical on the lowest aggregated level (elementary aggregate indices).

However, the purposes for which the two price indices are used differ to some extent. The focus of the HICP is on international comparison. Calculating comparable indices in the EU Member States that allow aggregation to obtain European price indices is especially important. The HICP's main purpose is to measure and compare inflation rates in Europe, while the CPI is designed to reflect the framework conditions in Germany and, to a larger extent, takes into account alternative goals like those of a compensation benchmark and of deflation. Unlike the CPI, the HICP includes neither imputed rents for owner-occupied housing nor radio licence fee. In the past, the differences in coverage have been even greater, e. g. motor vehicle tax and registration fee were not included in the HICP until December 2009 and the games of chance were not included until December 2025.

As a result of the implementation of ECOICOP Version 2 in the HICP, there are significant structural changes compared to ECOICOP Version 1, which bring about changes at the 2 to 5-digit level and must be partially covered by additional items. This includes new positions such as electric (kick) Scooter, as well as travel insurance premiums. The HICP transitioned to the new classification structures in 2025, while the CPI transitioned in 2028 with the CPI revision. Currently, there are differences between CPI and HICP, which also affect the scope of coverage and, in particular, the structure of the result evidence due to the time lag in implementing the new classification. The results below the overall index of CPI and HICP are sometimes difficult to compare.

In contrast to the CPI, the HICP is constructed as a chain index with an annually changing weighting pattern. Typically, figures of previous periods are not recalculated when reweighting the expenditure and incorporating methodological changes. Therefore comparability over time is possibly a bit more limited for the HICP than for the CPI. However, the former takes into account more recent consumption patterns.

- Retail price index (RPI): The RPI, too, is derived from the same data basis as the CPI and HICP. Unlike the HICP and the CPI, however, the RPI is a consumer price index with an institutional breakdown rather than a breakdown of individual consumption expenditure by purpose. The RPI covers only the households' retail purchases and is computed both with and without value-added tax to facilitate its use as a deflator for nominal variables (such as retail turnover).

- **National accounts:** The purpose of national accounts is to provide an overall quantitative picture of a national economy's activity over a given period of time. The picture should be as comprehensive as possible, clearly structured and sufficiently detailed. This includes reflecting the level of household final consumption expenditure in the economic territory. The relevant HICP and CPI concepts are largely based on the definition of final monetary consumption expenditure in national accounts. In addition, the rough weights (ECOICOP two to five-digit) are now updated annually based on the previous year's national accounts data.

Individual CPI results or sub-indices are often used in national accounting for deflating household final consumption expenditure in the domestic territory. However, modifications are carried out to make those results suitable for deflation purposes. As a matter of fact, the consumer price index and the relevant national accounts deflator differ for the simple reason that the underlying concepts are different (chain index and Laspeyres index with a fixed base).

Furthermore gaps in covering, for instance, illegal transactions or transactions that are difficult to measure (smuggling, illegal work, etc.) are filled with estimates in national accounting. In general, such cases are included neither in the HICP nor in the CPI although, in individual cases, the development of prices of comparable legal transactions is taken as a basis.

Like the CPI, the HICP includes both motor vehicle tax and private health insurance contributions (service proportion only). In national accounts, however, these are treated rather as social contributions than as consumption expenditure.

Contrary to the CPI, radio licence fees are not included in the national accounts or the HICP.

- **Further price indices for comparisons over time:** In addition to the HICP and the CPI, further price indices are available for comparisons over time. They include producer price indices, foreign trade price indices, the wholesale selling price index, and construction and real property price indices. Like the CPI and the HICP, all those indices are Laspeyres-type price indices. However, they reflect price development at other stages in the economic process and, in contrast to the HICP, do largely not include value-added tax. The prices of the same products may develop differently at various stages in the economic process as specific services (such as trade-related services) are added at those stages. Moreover, the HICP is the only index in the German price statistics which is designed as a chain index rather than a fixed-base index.
- **Purchasing power parities (PPPs), price level indices (PLIs):** To obtain information about price level differences between the individual countries, the Statistical Office of the European Union (Eurostat) computes so-called purchasing power parities in cooperation with the national statistical authorities. They form the basis for deriving, in a next step, price level indices. PPPs and PLIs are also constructed, among other things, for goods and services purchased by households for consumption purposes. In contrast to the HICP, the basket of goods and services for household final consumption expenditure is defined in an international coordination process. The weighting pattern for the PPPs is derived by each

participating country from the national accounts. It is based on the new ECOICOP, which is harmonised down to the five-digit level. The PPP and PLI concepts are designed exclusively for a geographical comparison of prices. Actually, the prices used to calculate PPPs and PLIs are only collected in Berlin, while CPI and HICP prices are collected in places all over Germany. Using adjustment factors which are derived from the average prices of selected products, the result for Berlin is extrapolated to Germany as a whole. The PLI computation further incorporates exchange rate information. Unlike the HICP, PLIs are consequently affected by fluctuations in exchange rates.

- Household budget surveys (sample survey of household income and expenditure, continuous household budget surveys): Household budget surveys provide important information about the structure of household final consumption expenditure in Germany. They form the main basis for establishing the weighting pattern for goods and services in the HICP and the CPI. However, the concepts and definitions of household budget surveys regarding household final consumption expenditure are not fully in line with those of the HICP. Although the classifications of the currently used sample survey of household income and expenditure and the CPI are both based on the German Classification of Income and Expenditure of Households, the breakdown of the results of the sample survey of household income and expenditure is not as fine as that of the CPI. And, typically, the sample survey of household income and expenditure is not carried out in a base year of consumer price statistics. Therefore, the results of the sample survey are supplemented and updated using the more detailed data of the continuous household budget surveys. Unlike the HICP and the CPI, the household budget surveys are based on the national concept and record sales in the private sector, too (like those of used cars). To calculate the weighting pattern for household final consumption expenditure, the results of the household budget surveys are adjusted and supplemented using further statistics. Consequently, the weighting pattern applied in the CPI and the HICP is not fully in line with the given structure of household final consumption expenditure in the household budget surveys.

7.2 Coherence - internal

The HICP is internally coherent. Clear rules based on European standards are in place for sampling and collecting prices and for compiling price series.

7.3 Input for other statistics

The HICP does not provide input for other official statistics in Germany. However, the German HICP is of course incorporated in HICP compilation at the European level (HICP for the European Monetary Union, HICP for the EU Member States).

8 Dissemination and communication

8.1 Dissemination format

News release

A press release is issued each time results are published. The press release is intended to communicate the most important results in a summarised form. The dates of publication are listed in an annual release calendar that is available publicly (see 8.3).

Publications

Major current results of the harmonised index of consumer prices (HICP) for Germany are published on the consumer price index theme page at www.destatis.de > Topics > Economy > Prices > Consumer price index under "Tables" (table "Harmonised index of consumer prices").

Online database

In the [GENESIS-Online database](#) (Code 61121), the results of the HICP for the total index and for sub-indices up to the 5-digit level from 1996 onwards (where available) can be retrieved in different file formats.

Micro-data access

Micro-data are not accessible.

Other

The results of the HICP for Germany and detailed results for the member states of the European Union are available on the website of the Statistical Office of the European Union (Eurostat).

8.2 Documentation on methodology

Articles on the harmonised index of consumer prices are contained in our Wirtschaft und Statistik scientific journal.

Currently relevant information are available on our website at www.destatis.de > Topics > Economy > Prices > Consumer price index > Methods.

8.3 Release policy

Release calendar

At the end of a calendar year, the release dates are announced for the following year.

Release calendar access

The current release calendar can be viewed on the website of the Federal Statistical Office: www.destatis.de > Press > Annual release calendar.

User access

The results of the HICP are available to all users at the same time on the website of the Federal Statistical Office.

9 Comment

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